

TURTLE KINGDOM

Build a living island, one believable join at a time.



36 CORE STEPS + 4 OPTIONAL EXTENSIONS

Source-based compositing • 1600 × 1200 pixels Masks, texture joins, contact shadows, foam and colour matching.

The cover is a teaching composite built from the supplied photographs. The earlier AI image is inspiration only, not the expected student result.

Read this before you begin

Multimedia 12 • Photoshop desktop • Surreal compositing

Suggested pacing: 5–6 classes of 70 minutes. Adjust after a short teacher trial.

The task

Create a sea turtle carrying a sandcastle kingdom. Combine the supplied photographs and make four joins work: castle to platform, platform to shell, turtle to ground, and foam to flipper.

What counts as success

- Create and repair purposeful layer masks.
- Use scale, overlap and contact shadows to combine photographs.
- Match local colour/brightness before applying a global finish.
- Explain and transfer a compositing decision without relying on a prepared asset.

How to follow a step

Select first identifies the active document, layer or thumbnail. Do the numbered actions, compare with the visual checkpoint, and use Why / Check / Fix before moving on. Save your PSD at the major stage boundaries.

IMPORTANT

The checkpoints and source-built reference are teaching composites assembled programmatically from the supplied photos, not Photoshop screenshots. The documented Photoshop workflow has not been executed end-to-end in Photoshop here. Settings are starting values, not a promise of identical pixels. The earlier AI image is inspiration only and is not the expected student output.

The full route uses seven originals. An eighth beach is included for an optional alternate mood. No generative Photoshop tools or paid third-party plug-ins are required for the core recipe.

Browser guide

Use index.html after extracting the complete ZIP, or the separate self-contained HTML file. The HTML includes downloadable originals, prepared supports, searchable steps and notes/backup tools. Export notes at the end of each session.

Your source images

Your ingredients: every component has a job



01 Ocean + foam
1600 x 1200 px



02 Dramatic sky
2048 x 1536 px



03 Turtle
2048 x 1173 px



04 Sand texture
2048 x 1536 px



05 Main castle
300 x 400 px



06 Twin gate
300 x 400 px



07 Cracked ground
1600 x 1302 px



08 Optional beach
1280 x 1024 px

Seven originals are used for the full build. The optional eighth beach supports E4. The small duplicate sandcastle4.jpg and the other sky/ground variants are not needed.

DETAIL The two castle originals are 300 × 400 pixels. A trimmed main castle is enlarged to roughly 390 pixels wide, so some softness is expected. This is a screen-sized compositing lesson, not a high-resolution print reconstruction.

Asset roles and attribution

Keep this ledger with the work. The supplied filenames are preserved. Attribution is reported from the supplied label or visible credit, not independently verified as a licence.

File / use	Attribution and status
honu_1_by_manaphoto_stock.jpg Turtle and shell	Manaphoto-stock (from the supplied filename); licence/terms not verified.
Sea__by_ephedrina_stock.jpg Ocean background and separate foam crop	Ephedrina-stock (from the supplied filename); licence/terms not verified.
clouds 1-2 - Copyright 2007 CausticStock.JPG Dramatic sky; crop excludes rooftops	Copyright 2007 CausticStock (as labelled in the supplied filename); terms not verified.
114147_1020.jpg High-resolution sand patch for the shell	Photographer/source to confirm; supplied by teacher.
sand_castle.jpg Tall central castle; 300 × 400 px	Photographer/source to confirm; supplied by teacher.
sand_castle_2_.jpg Twin gate reused at two sizes; 300 × 400 px	Photographer/source to confirm; supplied by teacher.
dry003.jpg Cracked-earth foreground	Kjherstin-stock (visible credit band on supplied image); terms not verified.
1180650_41162380.jpg Optional alternate beach for E4	Photographer/source to confirm; supplied by teacher.

RIGHTS Original filenames and visible credit bands are retained. Photographer identities and reuse permissions have not all been verified. Confirm rights before putting this source pack or students' derivative artwork on a public website. No public upload is included.

Controls and vocabulary

Action	Windows	Mac
Move tool	V	V
Brush / foreground-background swap	B / X	B / X
Free Transform / commit	Ctrl+T / Enter	Cmd+T / Return
Duplicate layer	Ctrl+J	Cmd+J
Invert the selected mask	Ctrl+I	Cmd+I
Deselect	Ctrl+D	Cmd+D
Show mask / restore normal view	Alt-click mask	Option-click mask
Disable / enable mask	Shift-click mask	Shift-click mask
Load a layer's visible pixels	Ctrl-click image thumbnail	Cmd-click image thumbnail
Fit on Screen / 100%	Ctrl+0 / Ctrl+1	Cmd+0 / Cmd+1

Four terms worth learning

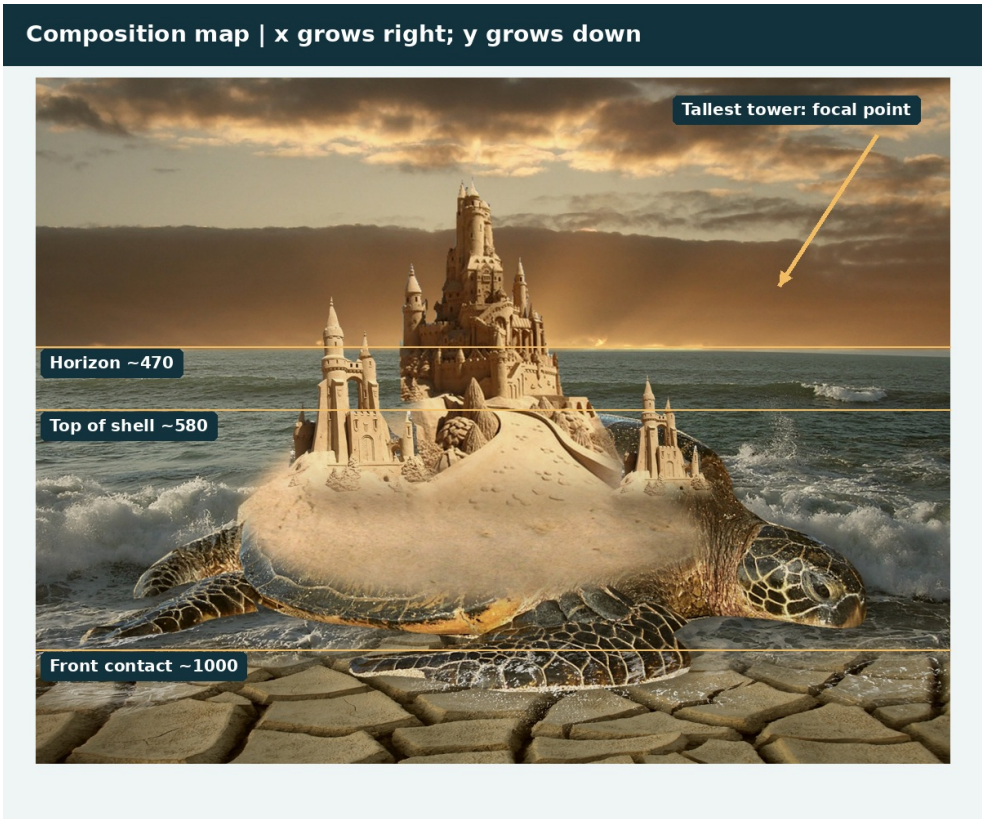
Selection: A temporary boundary that restricts an operation; it is not a separate layer.

Layer mask: A grayscale visibility map: black hides, white reveals, grey partially reveals.

Clipping mask: Uses the visible area of a lower base layer to limit the layers above it.

Smart Object: An embedded source container that supports revisable placement and scaling; it cannot invent missing original detail.

Composition measurements



Values refer to the top-left transform reference point. Preserve proportions for the turtle and buildings; resize texture crops deliberately. Hand-made masks may trim a few pixels differently.

Element	Size (px)	X, Y
Ocean (full source)	1600 × 1200	0, 150
Sky crop	1600 × ~938	0, -435
Turtle cut-out	1380 × ~496	75, 580
Sand texture before warp	870 × 355	335, 575
Main castle	390 × ~614	635, 172
Left gate	305 × ~357	405, 382
Right gate	190 × ~222	1000, 519
Ground texture crop	1600 × 570	0, 630
Foam crop	1600 × 330	0, 820

Layer order and supported route

Final layer order top of this list is front of the scene	
FINISH	Vignette / Colour Balance / global Curves
LIGHT	Dodge and Burn Curves, black masks
FOAM	Masked foam + Blend If; above the turtle
KINGDOM	Clipped corrections / gates / main castle
JOINS	Contact shadows / sand platform
TURTLE	Clipped correction / masked turtle
CONTACT	Turtle shadow
GROUND	Cracked texture + irregular layer mask
ATMOSPHERE	Low-opacity horizon haze
WORLD	Ocean correction / ocean + sky mask
SKY	Cropped replacement sky
BACKUP	Locked background / hidden references

Prepared supports

The PNG cut-outs and source-sized grayscale masks are optional access supports, not a finished layered project. Obtain teacher approval and declare every support used. A separate independent mask demonstration may still be needed.

The full-canvas Foam_Overlap_Canvas.png is placed at X0/Y0 and W1600; do not apply the cropped-foam transform to it. Other cut-out placements follow the measurement table. The full instructions for importing a grayscale mask are in the HTML supports panel.

No finished layered Photoshop PSD is included. The assessed PSD is the one the student builds.

Read the scene and collect the assets

SELECT The asset gallery and the source-built reference, not the AI concept.



The original photographs supplied for this project; optional beach is an extension asset.

1. Download the eight original photographs. Create a folder named Turtle_Kingdom_Lastname with subfolders Originals, Working, Exports and Evidence. Keep the supplied filenames inside Originals.
2. Use the source-built reference as the construction target. The earlier AI image is mood inspiration only; it contains invented castle detail and waves that are not present in the photographs.
3. Write one sentence about the story. Example: “A living island carries a fragile kingdom between dry land and the sea.” Identify the turtle, tallest tower and foreground as three depth zones.
4. Choose the full build or teacher-approved supported route. Prepared cut-outs save selection time but do not demonstrate your own masking skill. Record every support you use.

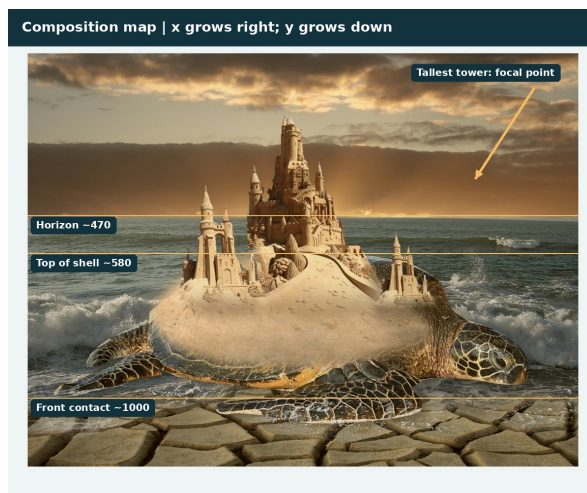
WHY	A composite is a planned relationship between images. Planning the focal point and depth prevents a collection of unrelated cut-outs.
CHECK	You have the originals, an empty working folder and a one-sentence intention. You can distinguish the actual reference from the AI concept.
FIX	Do not start by opening the AI concept and trying to extract its castle. Use sand_castle.jpg and sand_castle_2_.jpg.

Think: Which part should a viewer notice first, and what will make it stand out?

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Create a manageable master document

SELECT Photoshop desktop; no photograph needs to be active.



Layout guides are approximate design targets, not edges to cut along.

1. Choose File > New. Enter Width 1600 px, Height 1200 px, Resolution 72 pixels/inch, RGB Color, 8 bit and sRGB IEC61966-2.1. Use a white background and turn Artboards off.
2. Choose File > Save As. Save on your computer as Working/Turtle_Kingdom_Lastname_v01.psd. Keep this layered PSD throughout the project.
3. Open Window > Layers and Window > Properties. Turn on View > Rulers. Right-click a ruler and choose Pixels; reset the ruler origin to the upper-left by double-clicking the rulers' intersection.
4. Add horizontal guides at roughly y=470 (horizon), y=580 (shell top) and y=1000 (front contact). Drag from the top ruler while watching the position, or use View > Guides > New Guide.

WHY The small castle sources constrain detail. A 1600 × 1200 working image is practical for this exercise; changing the resolution number alone does not add detail.

CHECK The document is landscape, 4:3, and saved as a PSD. The guide positions match the blueprint.

FIX Check that Width and Height say px, not inches. Do not enlarge the canvas to a large print poster with these castle files.

Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Place the ocean without distorting it

SELECT The main PSD and its Background layer.



Later sky/colour checkpoint: at this step you still see the original pale sky.

1. Choose File > Place Embedded. Select Sea__by_ephedrina_stock.jpg, then press Enter/Return to finish the initial placement. Rename the layer 01_Ocean.
2. Press Ctrl+T (Windows) or Cmd+T (Mac). Enable the reference point in the options bar and select its top-left square. Keep width and height linked.
3. Enter W = 1600 px, X = 0 px and Y = 150 px. When a size field initially shows a percentage, include the px suffix. Commit with Enter/Return. Alternatively use Properties > Transform and the same dimensions.
4. The lower part of the photo extends outside the canvas; leave it there. Its real horizon should now sit close to y=470. Do not stretch the wave vertically to fill the top gap.

WHY	A consistent ocean perspective makes the later turtle scale easier to judge. Place Embedded preserves a source inside a Smart Object.
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CHECK	The wave spans the canvas. A temporary blank strip above the image is expected. The layer thumbnail has the Smart Object badge.
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FIX	A different placement size changes the horizon. Recheck W and the top-left reference point before changing X or Y.
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Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Mask the old sky, not the water

SELECT 01_Ocean, then its new layer-mask thumbnail.

Choose the correct thumbnail before you edit



Move / scale / filter the photograph



Hide / reveal / soften an edge

Black hides. White reveals. Grey partly reveals. The photograph is not erased.

Teaching schematic: image and mask thumbnails do different jobs; this is not a Photoshop screenshot.

1. With 01_Ocean selected, choose Layer > Layer Mask > Reveal All. Click the white mask thumbnail, not the photograph thumbnail.
2. Choose the Rectangular Marquee tool (M). Set Feather to 0. Select the entire area above y=470. Choose Edit > Fill > Black, then Select > Deselect.
3. With the mask still selected, open Window > Properties and start with Feather = 2 px. At 100% zoom, use a small soft Brush (B), black, Opacity 100%, to remove any remaining blue strip above the horizon.
4. Use white to restore any water you accidentally hide. Do not make a wide, soft band across the sea: keep the transition within about 5–12 pixels of its horizon.

WHY The mask hides the original sky while retaining the ocean. A narrow transition avoids a foggy double horizon.

CHECK The area above the sea is hidden, but wave detail is intact. Alt/Option-clicking the mask shows black above and white below.

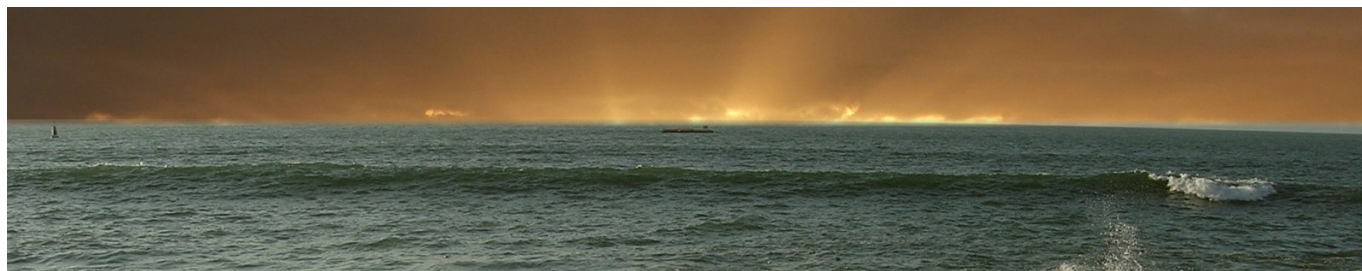
FIX Black paint on the picture is a wrong-thumbnail error. Undo, select the mask and paint again. A red X on a mask means it is disabled; Shift-click it once.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Fit the dramatic sky behind the horizon

SELECT A separate source tab for clouds 1-2 - Copyright 2007 CausticStock.JPG.



Close-up of the intended sky-ocean relationship after the first colour pass.

- 1.** Open the cloud photo. Immediately Save As Working/Sky_Crop.psd. Select the Rectangular Marquee tool; choose Style: Fixed Size, Width 2048 px and Height 1200 px. Click the original upper-left corner.
- 2.** Choose Image > Crop. This keeps the top 1200 pixels and excludes the distant buildings below. Save the working PSD; leave the original JPG untouched.
- 3.** Return to the master. Select Background and choose File > Place Embedded > Sky_Crop.psd. Rename the layer 00_Sky and place it below 01_Ocean.
- 4.** Free Transform the sky to $W = 1600$ px with linked proportions. Use the top-left reference: $X = 0$, $Y = -435$ px. Commit. The lower cloud crop extends slightly behind the ocean mask.
- 5.** Inspect the horizon at 100%. Adjust the ocean mask, not both photographs, to remove a bright seam. Keep one continuous horizon.

WHY Positioning a real cloud crop gives a reproducible sky without generating new scenery. Its overlap prevents an empty line between images.

CHECK Clouds fill the upper canvas. No roofs, tree silhouettes or second horizon appear over the sea.

FIX An empty strip means the two layers do not overlap. A hard blue line means some original ocean sky remains visible; paint that part of the ocean mask black.

Adobe technique notes [1, 2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Bring the sea into the same colour family

SELECT 01_Ocean photograph layer; add adjustments directly above it.



First world checkpoint: a coherent horizon and restrained warm-grey ocean.

1. Choose Layer > New Adjustment Layer > Curves. Name it Ocean_Tone and click OK. Choose Layer > Create Clipping Mask so it affects only 01_Ocean.
2. In Properties, leave the channel on RGB. Click near the centre of the curve, then type Input 128, Output 112. This is a starting value; keep foam detail visible.
3. Add a Hue/Saturation adjustment above it, clip it to the same ocean base, and start at Master Saturation -35. Add a clipped Color Balance adjustment: Midtones +10 Red, 0 Green, -10 Blue; Preserve Luminosity on.
4. Toggle the three adjustments off and on. The ocean should be less blue and slightly darker, not orange. Select the ocean and its clipped adjustments and group them as WORLD_OCEAN.

WHY Local corrections reduce the mismatch before a final overall grade. Clipping prevents the sea correction from also changing the sky.

CHECK The adjustment layers have clipping arrows, and only the ocean changes when their visibility is toggled.

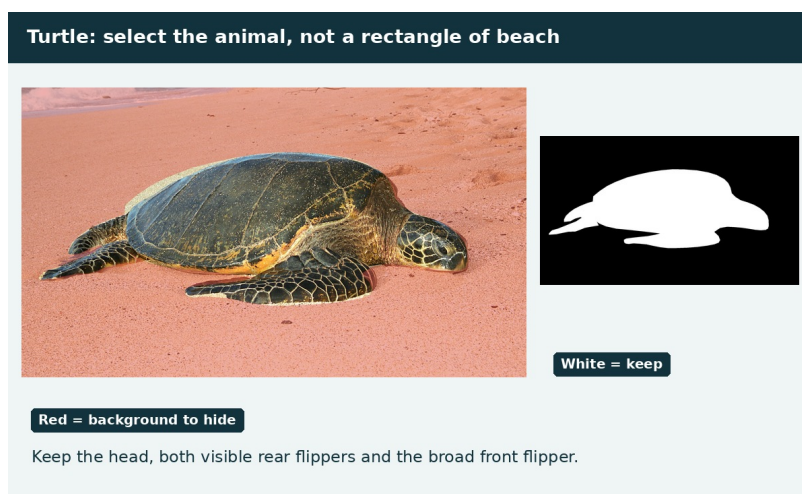
FIX When the whole scene changes, the adjustment is not clipped. Select it and choose Layer > Create Clipping Mask. Start more subtly if the foam becomes muddy.

Adobe technique notes [3, 4, 12]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Select the turtle in its original photograph

SELECT honu_1_by_manaphoto_stock.jpg in its own document.



The red overlay marks background to hide; the adjacent white shape shows what to retain.

1. Open the turtle original and Save As Working/Turtle_Cutout.psd. Press Ctrl/Cmd+J to duplicate Background and hide the original Background layer.
2. Convert the visible duplicate with Layer > Smart Objects > Convert to Smart Object. Rename it Turtle_Source.
3. Choose Object Selection from the W tool group and draw around the whole turtle. Include the broad front flipper, the head and the two visible rear flippers.
4. For missed parts, use the Quick Selection tool in Add mode. Use Subtract mode for unwanted sand. A manual alternative is Polygonal Lasso: click short segments around the silhouette, Shift to add and Alt/Option to subtract.

WHY	Working at source size makes the silhouette easier to judge. An automatic result is a starting selection, not a finished mask.
CHECK	The marching ants follow the whole turtle rather than a rectangle of its original beach.
FIX	Do not include pale sand merely because it touches a flipper. Zoom in and subtract it. When automatic selection is unavailable, use the manual Lasso route.

Adobe technique notes [5]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Refine the hard edges without losing anatomy

SELECT The active turtle selection in Turtle_Cutout.psd.

Edge check | inspect the head and flipper at 100%



No strip of source sand.



No missing flipper tip.

Source-derived edge enlargements on a dark inspection background.

1. Choose Select > Select and Mask. View the selection On Black, then On White. These contrasting views reveal different fringes.
2. Start with Radius 1 px, Smooth 1, Feather 0.4 px, Contrast 10% and Shift Edge -5%. Leave Decontaminate Colors off. Inspect before accepting; these are not mandatory values.
3. Use the ordinary Brush tool inside Select and Mask for small additions/subtractions. Do not sweep Refine Edge Brush over the hard shell or eye; these are not hair edges.
4. Set Output To: Layer Mask and click OK. Toggle the original background off if needed. Fix remaining sand on the mask with a small brush; paint white to restore a missing flipper tip.

WHY Clean edges help integration more than a large blur. A small inward shift can reduce sand fringes while preserving the turtle's outline.

CHECK There is no pale halo around the head and no chopped-off front flipper. The subject stays opaque, not translucent.

FIX An over-soft edge usually means too much Feather or Radius. Reopen Select and Mask and reduce them; do not compensate with heavy sharpening.

Adobe technique notes [5]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Place the turtle at the intended scale

SELECT The masked turtle source; then the master PSD.



Turtle placement and contact-shadow checkpoint; shadows are added next.

1. With only the cut-out visible, choose Image > Trim > Transparent Pixels; trim Top, Bottom, Left and Right. Save Turtle_Cutout.psd. Do not flatten it.
2. In the master, select WORLD_OCEAN. File > Place Embedded > Turtle_Cutout.psd. Rename the placed layer 03_Turtle.
3. Free Transform with linked proportions to W = 1380 px. Using the top-left reference point, enter X = 75 px and Y = 580 px. Commit.
4. Your hand-made mask can trim a few pixels differently. Aim for a shell top near y=580 and the front flipper near y=1075. Keep the head inside the right edge.
5. Supported route: place prepared_supports/Turtle_Cutout.png with the same width and position. Record this support; do not claim the prepared mask as your own selection.

WHY A large turtle anchors the composition. Its visible shell rim will later sell the idea that the kingdom rests on a living carrier.

CHECK The head faces right and all visible flippers fit on the canvas. The turtle occupies most of the width.

FIX If the whole original beach appears, the original Background remained visible in the source PSD. Hide it, save, and replace/re-place the embedded source.

Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Add a close contact shadow under the turtle

SELECT 03_Turtle in the master; create the shadow immediately beneath it.



Close-contact area beneath the turtle; the final foreground will be blended later.

1. Ctrl-click/Cmd-click the 03_Turtle image thumbnail to load its visible pixels. Create a new empty pixel layer below it and name it 02_Turtle_Contact.
2. Set the foreground colour to #30271A. Choose Edit > Fill > Foreground Color, then Select > Deselect. Move this shadow 8 px right and 10 px down with the Move tool.
3. Choose Filter > Blur > Gaussian Blur, Radius 10-12 px. Set the layer blend mode to Multiply and start at 40% opacity.
4. Add a white layer mask. Paint black over any shadow visible above the shell or around the top of the head. Keep the darkest contact near the underside and flipper bases, not as an all-around outline.

WHY A close, soft contact shadow connects the animal to the surface. Removing the upper halo prevents a sticker-like drop shadow.

CHECK The turtle feels heavier. The surrounding wave is not darkened by a giant silhouette.

FIX A floating turtle needs a closer/darker underside shadow, not a much larger blur. Lower opacity when the shadow looks like a black border.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Match the turtle before hiding part of its shell

SELECT 03_Turtle, with corrections placed directly above it.



Early integration checkpoint: preserve texture while reducing the source-lighting mismatch.

1. Add Curves, choose Layer > Create Clipping Mask, and name it Turtle_Tone. Start at Input 128, Output 116.
2. Add a clipped Hue/Saturation adjustment with Master Saturation -15. Add clipped Color Balance: Midtones +8 Red, 0 Green, -8 Blue. Keep Preserve Luminosity on.
3. At Fit on Screen, compare the brightest shell and flipper highlights with the nearby water. Reduce the adjustments if the head loses detail.
4. Create a temporary Black & White adjustment at the very top of the document for a brightness comparison. Inspect, then delete this temporary diagnostic layer. Save v02.

WHY Brightness differences remain visible even when colours match. The temporary monochrome view helps separate a tone problem from a colour problem.

CHECK The turtle retains its dark shell, detailed eye and patterned flippers, with no strong yellow or blue fringe.

FIX A black turtle is over-darkened. Lift Turtle_Tone or reduce its opacity; do not brighten the entire background to compensate.

Adobe technique notes [3, 4, 12]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Extract a useful patch of real sand

SELECT 114147_1020.jpg in a separate source tab.



The highlighted rectangle identifies the actual source region used for the platform.

1. Open the original and Save As Working/Sand_Texture_Patch.psd. Use Rectangular Marquee, Style Fixed Size, Width 648 px and Height 490 px.
2. Place the selection at approximately x=1400, y=1000. This samples the lower-right slope, not the tower, water or dark tunnel. Use the marked source map to check the location.
3. Choose Image > Crop and save the working PSD. Return to the master and File > Place Embedded the patch above the turtle corrections.
4. Rename the new layer 04_Sand_Platform. Supported route: use Sand_Texture_Patch.jpg from prepared_supports; it is the same cropped source region, not a newly generated texture.

WHY Real sand texture already contains grain and tonal variation. A clean patch is easier to blend than an entire sandcastle photograph.

CHECK Only the sandy slope fills the patch. There are no blue areas, sea foam, buildings or dark tunnel shapes.

FIX The tiny sandcastle4.jpg is a low-resolution duplicate of the larger image. Use 114147_1020.jpg, not that thumbnail.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Shape the texture to the shell's surface

SELECT 04_Sand_Platform image thumbnail, not its future mask.

Sand platform | bend the surface, keep the shell rim



Target shape and retained shell rim. Warp handles vary with the installed Photoshop version.

1. Free Transform the patch. Temporarily unlink width and height and enter W = 870 px, H = 355 px; place its top-left at X = 335, Y = 575. Commit.
2. Choose Edit > Transform > Warp. Use a 3 × 3 grid where available. Gently raise the two lower corners about 30–40 px while keeping the centre lower: the base should follow a shallow curved shell.
3. Move the top-middle control only a little, keeping the texture inside the shell. Commit with Enter/Return. Texture can be reshaped; towers and the turtle must not be stretched this way.
4. Lower the layer opacity briefly to 50% to see the shell beneath. Check the fit, then restore 100% before masking in the next step.

WHY The platform needs to read as a surface turning over a dome. The warp is a small form adjustment, not a way to bend architecture.

CHECK The texture covers the upper shell and leaves room for a visible lower rim. Its grain is not dragged into obvious streaks.

FIX A severe warp is hard to repair. Undo and make smaller moves, or keep the initial transformed patch and let the mask define its curve.

Adobe technique notes [6]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Mask the sand to the upper shell

SELECT 04_Sand_Platform; add a hide-all mask.

Sand platform | bend the surface, keep the shell rim



The centre stays textured; only the contact boundary softly transitions into the shell.

1. Choose Layer > Layer Mask > Hide All. The texture disappears; that is expected. Click its black mask thumbnail.
2. Choose a soft round Brush (B), white, Size about 180 px, Hardness 0%, Opacity 100%, Flow 25%. Paint several passes over the upper shell to reveal the central platform.
3. Use a smaller 50–80 px brush near its boundary. Follow the dome from about (360,780) through (750,585) to (1170,820), then curve back across the lower shell.
4. Keep the head, neck, flippers and original lower shell rim uncovered. Use black at 20–30% opacity to fade the sandy edge; keep central sand mostly opaque.
5. Alt/Option-click the mask to inspect it, then Alt/Option-click again to return to the scene.

WHY A local mask makes a sand-covered shell, not a beige sticker or a replacement animal. The rim provides a crucial continuity cue.

CHECK A continuous original shell rim is still visible below the sand. No sand appears on the eye or across a flipper.

FIX A perfect oval looks artificial. Break up the boundary with varied brush sizes and short strokes. Do not reduce the opacity of the entire turtle.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Give the sand platform light and volume

SELECT 04_Sand_Platform; all following corrections are clipped to it.



Sand platform checkpoint. Exact tonal settings are starting values, not a fixed colour preset.

1. Add a clipped Curves adjustment named Sand_Tone. Start with Input 128, Output 138 to lift the midtone. Add a clipped Hue/Saturation adjustment with Saturation -10 if the sand is too yellow.
2. Add another clipped Curves adjustment named Sand_Shade. Set Input 128, Output 105. Select its white mask and press Ctrl/Cmd+I to turn it black.
3. With a soft white brush, Opacity 15%, Flow 20%, paint on the Sand_Shade mask along the lower-right quarter of the platform. Build the shading slowly.
4. Leave the upper-left side lighter. Toggle Sand_Shade to check that the platform gains a rounded form without becoming a flat grey patch.

WHY Texture alone does not create form. A restrained lighter-to-darker transition helps the platform read as sand resting on a curved shell.

CHECK The platform has a bright upper-left area and a darker underside. Individual sand texture remains visible.

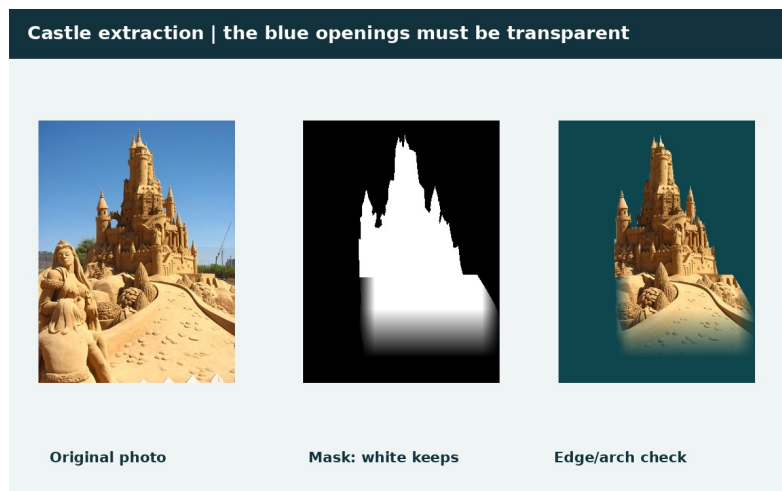
FIX When everything darkens, the shade layer is not clipped or its mask was not inverted. Check both before adjusting the curve.

Adobe technique notes [3, 4]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Start the main castle mask

SELECT sand_castle.jpg in a new source document.



Source, example mask and inspection view. The mask is a guide, not an assessed student product.

1. Open sand_castle.jpg. Save As Working/Castle_Main_Cutout.psd. Duplicate Background, hide the original and convert the duplicate to a Smart Object.
2. Zoom to 200–300%. This enlarges your view, not the photo's real detail. Use Polygonal Lasso to enclose the tall central castle and the curving sand path below it.
3. Leave out the large sand figure on the left, the distant skyline and the far-right background. The selection may still include small blue gaps between turrets.
4. Click Add Layer Mask. Keep the castle visible and the outer background hidden. Do not trim yet; the source coordinates still need to match the selection reference.

WHY An initial coarse mask establishes the useful region. Fine sky holes and edge cleanup are separate, manageable tasks.

CHECK The central tower, its surrounding turrets and the curving foreground path remain. The left figure does not dominate the cut-out.

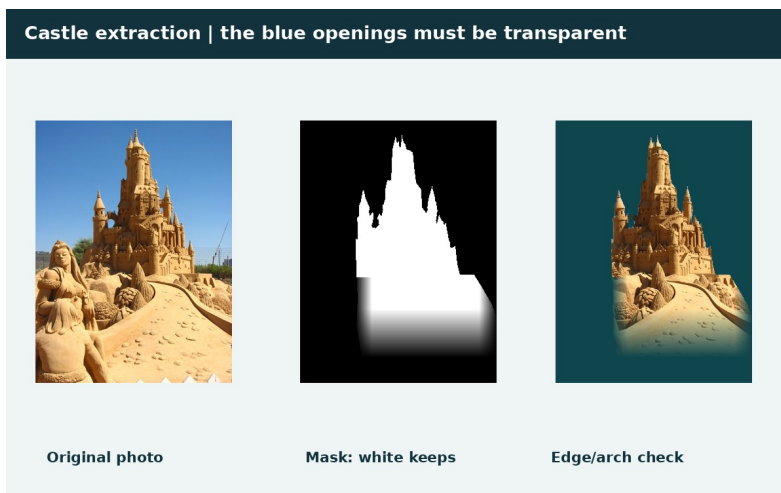
FIX Do not chase every grain at 800% zoom. The source is only 300 × 400 pixels; it cannot supply large-print detail.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Remove blue sky between the turrets

SELECT The Castle_Main source IMAGE thumbnail first; its existing MASK second.



Use the mask to distinguish unwanted blue sky from real dark architectural detail.

1. Choose Select > Color Range. Set Select to Sampled Colors, Fuzziness around 40, and leave Localized Color Clusters off. Sample a blue patch between turrets.
2. Use the plus eyedropper or hold Shift while clicking other blue shades. In the preview, white should indicate blue sky to be removed. Stop if warm stone begins to turn white.
3. Click OK. Now click the EXISTING mask thumbnail. Choose Edit > Fill > Black to hide the selected blue pixels; Select > Deselect.
4. Inspect the small gaps and arch openings. Keep genuinely dark doors and cast shadows; remove only blue/background holes. Paint small repairs on the mask.

WHY Colour-based selection is useful because blue sky differs from warm sand. It does not distinguish architecture from background on its own.

CHECK No blue fragments remain between the spires. Sand windows and shaded walls are still intact.

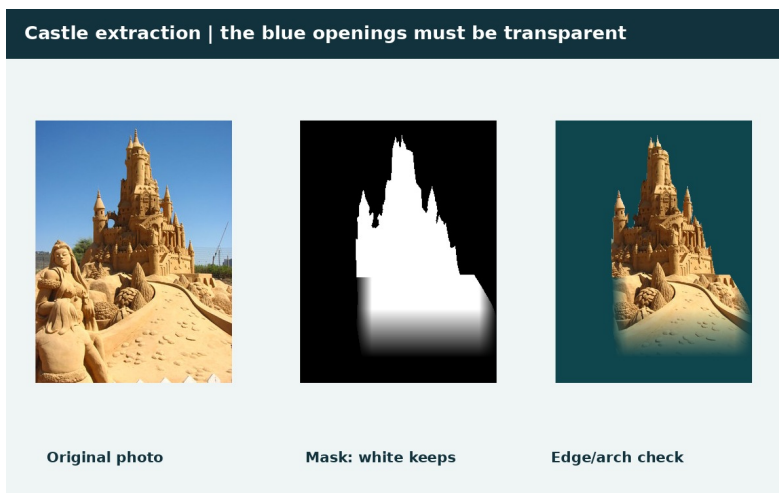
FIX Filling the image layer instead of the mask paints the castle black. Undo immediately. A huge Fuzziness value can remove pale stone along with the sky.

Adobe technique notes [7]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Clean, trim and save the main castle

SELECT Castle_Main_Cutout.psd and its mask.



A hard building edge needs far less feathering than sea spray.

1. Open Select > Select and Mask with the layer mask active. Start with Smooth 0, Feather 0.2 px, Contrast 10% and Shift Edge -3%. Keep Decontaminate Colors off; Output To: Layer Mask.
2. Inspect the spire tips against both dark and light backgrounds. Use a 2-5 px mask brush for repairs, not a large Refine Edge sweep.
3. With the original Background hidden, choose Image > Trim > Transparent Pixels and trim all four sides. Save the layered PSD.
4. Supported route: Castle_Main_Cutout.png is supplied with a prepared mask. In either route, keep a copy before blending the lower path so you can recover it later.

WHY A trimmed transparent asset has a meaningful size when placed. Preserving the source mask keeps the edge decisions reversible.

CHECK The castle is on transparency with its tips present and no blue halo. Only the useful region determines its bounds.

FIX A disappearing thin spire needs less Shift Edge, not more feathering. If your bounds differ a little, use the visible placement target in the next step.

Adobe technique notes [5]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Place the main castle on the shell

SELECT The master PSD; select the top sand adjustment.



Main-castle checkpoint before the gates and final contact corrections.

1. File > Place Embedded > Castle_Main_Cutout.psd. Rename it 05_Castle_Main. In Free Transform, keep proportions linked and set W = 390 px.
2. Use the top-left reference point: X = 635, Y = 172. Commit. The exact height depends on your trim; the prepared example is approximately 614 px tall.
3. The castle's path should extend into the sandy platform, not stop at the shell's highest point. The top spire should have clear sky around it.
4. Do not warp the entire castle to bend the path. Keep towers vertical and blend the bottom with a second, outer mask. Save v03 before doing that.

WHY The centre spire establishes hierarchy while the path creates a visual route down into the shell. Overlap gives room for a convincing join.

CHECK The tallest spire is near the central upper third. The base overlaps the platform; it does not float above it.

FIX The prepared castle is enlarged roughly 180% after trimming. Some softness is expected. Do not promise new detail by changing the resolution number.

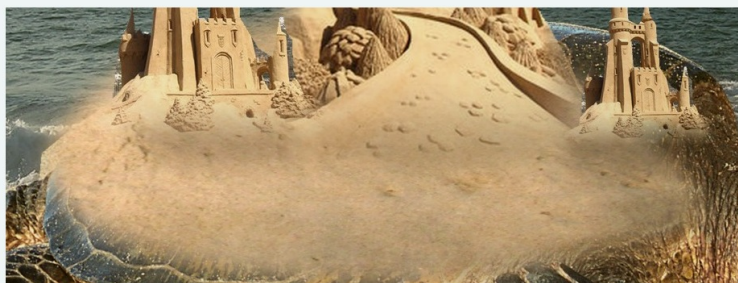
Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Blend the castle's base into the sand

SELECT 05_Castle_Main outer layer mask in the master, not the embedded source mask.

Join check | fade sand, not the standing walls



Close join target: blend only the sandy skirt, not the entire castle.

1. Add a white mask to the placed 05_Castle_Main layer. Use a soft black Brush, Size 70 px, Hardness 0%, Opacity 20%, Flow 20%.
2. Fade the bottom of the path into the platform in several short passes. Work across the lower 70–100 px of the visible castle footprint; vary the edge rather than making a straight line.
3. Use a smaller brush to soften the lower left/right corners where the source rectangle becomes visible. Keep standing walls and stairs above the join opaque.
4. Toggle the castle off and on. The platform must continue underneath it. Refine the platform mask when its colour or edge changes abruptly at the castle foot.

WHY The source photograph already has sand around the castle. Blending that sand into the platform hides the photographic boundary without destroying architecture.

CHECK There is no visible rectangular foot or translucent wall. The path seems to meet the shell surface.

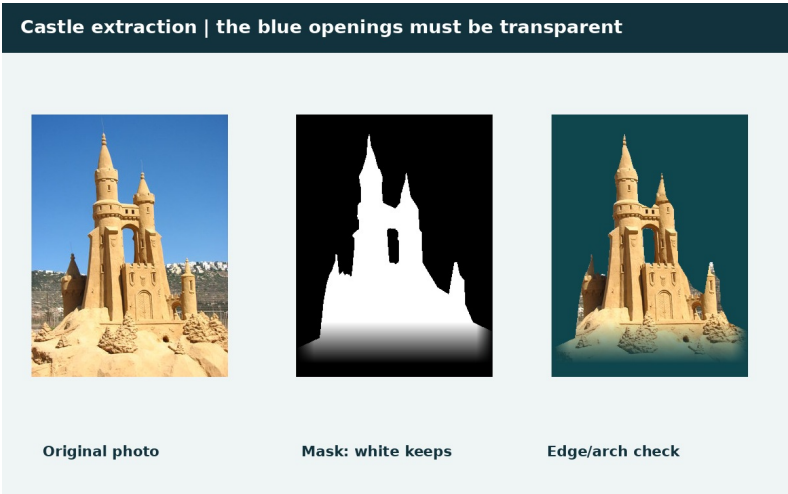
FIX Fading the whole castle is the wrong fix. Return its layer opacity to 100% and work locally on the outer mask.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Extract the twin-tower gate and its opening

SELECT sand_castle_2_.jpg in its own working document.



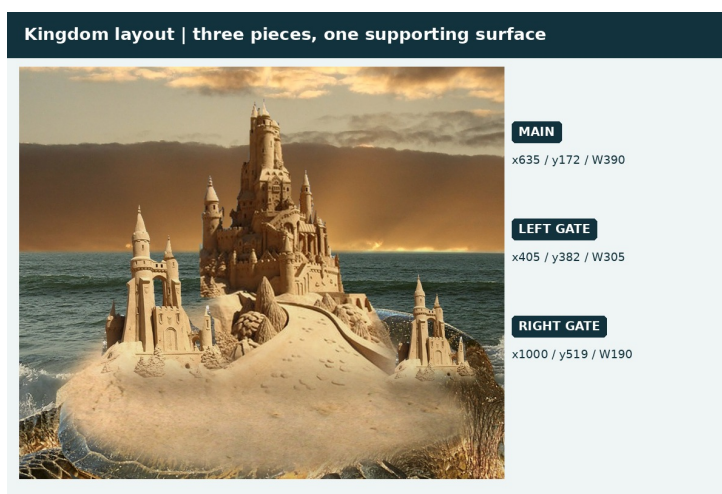
- The large central arch is a background opening; the lower dark door is architectural detail.
1. Open the gate photo and Save As Working/Castle_Gate_Cutout.psd. Duplicate and hide Background; convert the duplicate to a Smart Object.
 2. Use Polygonal Lasso to enclose the two towers and the sand at their feet. Add a mask. Exclude the distant hillside and buildings, especially left and right of the gate.
 3. Use Select > Color Range to select blue, then fill that selection black on the existing mask as in step 17. The blue area INSIDE the tall arch must also disappear.
 4. Use a small mask brush to remove any distant landscape still visible inside the arch. Leave the genuinely dark doorway below. Trim transparent pixels and save.
 5. Supported route: Castle_Gate_Cutout.png. The same prepared gate will be used twice at different sizes; this is not a separate third castle photo.

WHY	An opening must reveal whatever is behind the building in the new scene, not its old sky. Interior holes are part of a complete mask.
CHECK	You can see transparency through the large arch. The top tips remain intact and the lower sand can be blended.
FIX	A blue arch is easy to miss at Fit on Screen. Check it at 100% before placing the gate.

Adobe technique notes [2, 7]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.
☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Arrange gates at two different depths

SELECT The master document above 05_Castle_Main.



Position values are a starting layout. Match visible bases if your trimmed bounds differ.

1. Place the gate PSD as an embedded Smart Object. Name it 06_Gate_Left. Set W = 305 px, X = 405, Y = 382 with linked proportions and a top-left reference.
2. Duplicate it with Ctrl/Cmd+J. Name the duplicate 07_Gate_Right. Set W = 190 px, X = 1000, Y = 519. Keep both gates above the main castle in layer order.
3. Add an outer white mask to each gate and blend its lower sand into the platform, as in step 20. Do not fade the walls or leave rectangular corners.
4. Keep the smaller gate darker by a small amount when you match tone. Avoid horizontally flipping the gate only to make it different: that also reverses the photographed light direction.

WHY Size differences and overlap create depth. Reusing one asset can work when its placement supports a clear visual hierarchy.

CHECK The main castle stays tallest; the gates do not compete equally. All three pieces meet the same sandy platform.

FIX A gate standing on the turtle's neck is misplaced. Move it left/up or reduce it until the base sits within the platform.

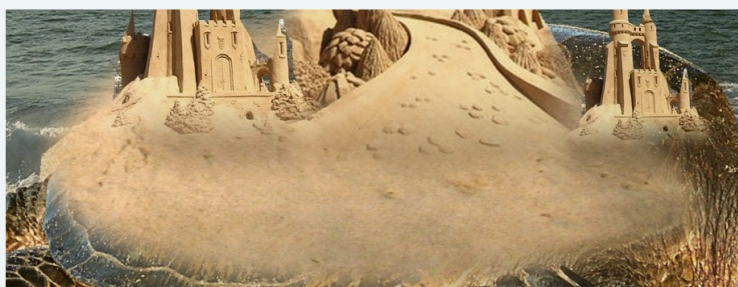
Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Paint restrained shadows at the building feet

SELECT A new pixel layer above the sand platform but BELOW all three castle pieces.

Join check | fade sand, not the standing walls



Paint at actual contact points; do not apply a uniform Drop Shadow to the whole skyline.

1. Create a pixel layer named 08_Castle_Contact. Set its blend mode to Multiply. Choose foreground #443118 and a soft round Brush about 45 px.
2. At Brush Opacity 15% and Flow 20%, paint short contact marks immediately beneath the gate bases and the main path where they touch sand.
3. Make the contact darkest at the base and let it soften toward the lower right. Add a white layer mask to hide spill outside the platform.
4. Toggle this layer. You should feel the buildings settle onto the shell without noticing black ovals. Lower the layer opacity before increasing the blur.

WHY Contact shadows explain where two surfaces meet. They should not appear around the skyline or detach from the buildings.

CHECK The castle feet feel grounded. No dark halo follows the spires or arches.

FIX A large shadow under a tiny gate makes it float. Bring the shadow closer to the foot and reduce its size.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Match the castle pieces to one another

SELECT Each castle IMAGE layer separately; keep its corrections clipped.



Kingdom construction checkpoint before foreground texture and front foam.

1. Above 05_Castle_Main, add clipped Curves with Input 128, Output 122. Add clipped Hue/Saturation with Master Saturation -18. Start with subtle warming in clipped Color Balance: Midtones +6 Red, 0 Green, -6 Blue.
2. Repeat with separate clipped adjustments for the left gate. For the smaller right gate, begin slightly darker: Curves Input 128, Output 116.
3. Compare the sand at all three bases to the platform. Adjust these values until the differences look like lighting, not three unrelated photographs.
4. Select the three castles, their clipped adjustments and 08_Castle_Contact, then group as KINGDOM. Keep the platform in its own group/layer below. Save v04.

WHY Local matching comes before the global grade. Similar sand should share a colour family while retaining different light and shadow areas.

CHECK The three pieces still have depth, but no one gate looks pasted in from midday while the others look like dusk.

FIX A correction that changes several unrelated objects is not clipped to the intended base. Expand the group and inspect the clipping arrows.

Adobe technique notes [3, 4, 12]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Prepare the cracked-earth foreground

SELECT dry003.jpg in its own source document.

Foreground | an irregular boundary, not a horizontal cut



Foreground scale target. The original stock credit is retained in the packaged source file.

1. Open dry003.jpg and Save As Working/Ground_Patch.psd. The original contains a creator credit band; keep the original intact and record the credit in your source log.
2. Use Rectangular Marquee, Fixed Size 1600 × 1197 px, beginning at x=0, y=105. Choose Image > Crop and save the working texture crop.
3. In the master, select WORLD_OCEAN. Place Ground_Patch.psd above it but BELOW the turtle shadow. Rename it 09_Cracked_Ground.
4. Free Transform to W = 1600 px, H = 570 px with proportions temporarily unlinked; X = 0, Y = 630. This deliberate vertical compression turns a texture into a shallow foreground plane.
5. Add clipped Curves at Input 128, Output 114 and clipped Hue/Saturation near -25. Begin warming with Color Balance +12 Red, 0 Green, -10 Blue.

WHY The foreground needs larger crack shapes near the viewer. Keeping it below the turtle preserves the animal's clean silhouette.

CHECK The texture reaches the bottom edge. The original photograph and its attribution remain in your Originals folder and source log.

FIX Do not claim the stock is public domain because it was provided. The visible credit is Kjherstin-stock; public sharing permissions still need confirmation.

Adobe technique notes [1, 12]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Make an irregular land-to-shore transition

SELECT 09_Cracked_Ground MASK thumbnail.

Foreground | an irregular boundary, not a horizontal cut



The material transition should vary across the frame and remain behind the turtle.

1. Add a hide-all mask to 09_Cracked_Ground. Use a white soft brush about 250 px, Opacity 100%, Flow 25%, to reveal the texture along the bottom of the frame.
2. Build upward toward y=970–1020, varying the boundary. Let a few crack shapes reach closer to the turtle and leave other places as wet sand.
3. Switch to a smaller black brush to hide a repeated or straight edge. The texture must remain below the turtle; do not paint a crack over the eye or flippers.
4. Inspect at 50%. Keep a transition zone of wet sand/foam between sea and dry plates rather than an abrupt dry-to-wet stripe.

WHY An irregular boundary follows the visual logic of a shoreline. The dry-earth foreground is a deliberate surreal choice, not a claim about a real beach.

CHECK The cracks sit in the foreground without looking like a rectangular carpet. The turtle's contact shadow still appears above them.

FIX A dark horizontal bar usually comes from the crop's top edge. Hide that edge with the mask, rather than blurring the entire texture.

Adobe technique notes [2]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Harvest real foam from the ocean image

SELECT A fresh copy of Sea__by_ephedrina_stock.jpg, before the world colour corrections.

Blend If | separate white foam from darker water



110: fully hidden below

207: fully visible above

Split the BLACK slider on THIS LAYER. Leave Underlying Layer unchanged.

The upper strip shows the actual source crop. The diagram below explains the next operation.

1. Open the ocean source again and Save As Working/Foam_Patch.psd. Use Rectangular Marquee with Fixed Size 1600 × 400 px, starting at x=0, y=590.
2. Choose Image > Crop and save. This is the lower breaking-wave and foam region, not the sky. In the master, Place Embedded above the KINGDOM group and all subject layers.
3. Rename it 10_Foam_Overlap. Set its dimensions to W = 1600, H = 330 px, top-left X = 0, Y = 820. Commit; the rectangular patch will cover much of the scene temporarily.
4. Leave the blend mode Normal. Do not set Screen as a shortcut: it can brighten all of the dark water as well as the foam.

WHY The same ocean photo supplies consistent water texture. Keeping a separate overlap layer lets foam sit in front of selected contact edges.

CHECK You have an independent foam source layer above the turtle, ready to separate its light pixels.

FIX The source must be the uncorrected original for the next numeric Blend If starting values. A pre-darkened crop may need different thresholds.

Adobe technique notes [1]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Use split Blend If to remove darker water

SELECT 10_Foam_Overlap image layer, not a layer mask.

Blend If | separate white foam from darker water



Conceptual Blend If explanation, not an invented Photoshop interface screenshot.

1. Double-click the empty space to the right of the layer name to open Layer Style. Choose Blending Options. Under Blend If, leave Gray selected.
2. Use the TOP ramp labelled This Layer. Move its black slider toward 110, then hold Alt/Option and drag the right half of that black slider toward 207.
3. The split should read approximately 110 / 207 at the dark end. Leave the white end at 255 and leave the Underlying Layer sliders unchanged. Click OK.
4. Dark water is hidden, midtones become partly transparent and pale foam remains. Add a clipped Hue/Saturation adjustment near -80 if the isolated foam looks blue.

WHY Splitting the slider gives a gradual tonal fade rather than a harsh cut-off. This is an editable blending rule, not erased pixels.

CHECK Most of the dark water rectangle disappears. Foam remains textured rather than becoming solid white.

FIX Dragging Underlying Layer changes where the scene beneath shows through; it is the wrong ramp here. Reset it and split the This Layer black slider instead.

Adobe technique notes [8]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Reveal foam only where surfaces overlap

SELECT 10_Foam_Overlap layer mask.

Occlusion | foam overlaps only the lowest contact edges



Foam crosses the lowest edge of the front flipper, not its whole upper surface.

1. Choose Layer > Layer Mask > Hide All. With its black mask active, use a soft white brush, Size 100–160 px, Opacity 25%, Flow 20%.
2. Reveal small areas near the rear-left contact, along the lowest front-flipper edge and at the wet sand to the right. Use the close-up as a location guide.
3. Keep the eye, head top, shell centre and castles entirely free of foam. Avoid one uninterrupted white band across the turtle.
4. Use black to remove repeating patterns or high foam that looks like it climbs a vertical wall. Optional support: place Foam_Overlap_Canvas.png at W1600, X0, Y0; it already includes the crop and mask, so do not apply the crop transform again.

WHY A little foreground overlap creates depth: the turtle is in the scene instead of sitting on top of it. Restraint keeps the subject readable.

CHECK At least one lower contact edge is partly overlapped by real foam, while the eye and most of the flipper remain clear.

FIX A white halo suggests too much brush coverage or an overly permissive Blend If range. Repair the mask before changing the source.

Adobe technique notes [2, 8]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Separate distance with subtle horizon haze

SELECT A new pixel layer above the world but BELOW the cracked ground and turtle.



Lighting checkpoint; the haze belongs between the background and the subject.

1. Create a layer named 11_Horizon_Haze. Choose foreground #F1D8B1 and a soft round brush, Size 350–500 px, Opacity 10%, Flow 10%.
2. Paint one broad pass just above and below the distant horizon, approximately y=450–520. Do not paint across the entire image.
3. Lower layer opacity to 15–30% if the haze becomes obvious. Add a mask to remove it from places where a detailed crest should remain crisp.
4. Toggle it at Fit on Screen. Keep it only if it gently separates the castle/turtle from distant water. It is acceptable for this layer to be barely visible.

WHY Reducing distant contrast can suggest atmospheric depth. Putting haze behind the subject prevents it from bleaching the eye and flippers.

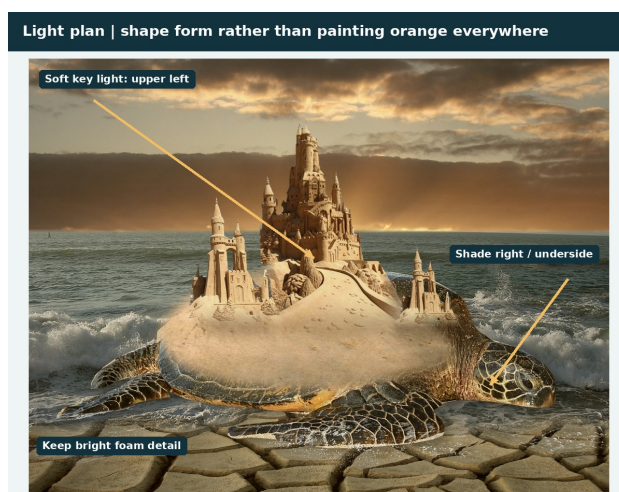
CHECK The distance feels slightly softer while the foreground stays crisp. The horizon is still identifiable.

FIX A beige stripe means the brush band is too narrow or too opaque. Soften the mask and lower opacity; do not blur the whole scene.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Dodge and burn with editable Curves masks

SELECT Two new Curves adjustments above the assembled scene.



The arrows are an artistic lighting plan, not a measurement of a physical sun position.

1. Add Curves named 12_Dodge. Set RGB Input 128, Output 151. Set this adjustment layer's blend mode to Luminosity. Invert its white mask to black.
2. Add Curves named 13_Burn. Set Input 128, Output 105, blend mode Luminosity, and invert its mask to black.
3. On the Dodge mask, paint white using a soft brush, Opacity 10%, Flow 10%, over small upper-left-facing edges: selected tower edges, shell ridge and flipper highlights.
4. On the Burn mask, paint white along the lower-right side of the sand platform and a few contact areas. Keep the eye and the brightest foam detail visible.
5. Compare on/off. The goal is a consistent soft upper-left key light already suggested by the photographs—not a new hard sun that contradicts their shadows.

WHY Separate masks let you brighten and darken locally without painting colour over the photos. Luminosity limits unwanted saturation changes.

CHECK Form is clearer but brush strokes are not visible. Towers remain textured instead of glowing white.

FIX Visible white paint means you selected a pixel layer instead of the Curves mask. Undo and target the black mask. Reduce the adjustment opacity when needed.

Adobe technique notes [3]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Apply a restrained overall grade

SELECT The top of the layer stack, above Dodge and Burn.



A close-up colour target. Your grade will vary with the mask, monitor and source placement.

1. Add an UNCLIPPED Curves adjustment called 14_Global_Contrast. Start with points Input/Output 64/59, 128/128 and 192/198. Keep endpoints at 0/0 and 255/255.
2. Add an unclipped Color Balance adjustment called 15_Global_Warmth. Start with Midtones +4 Red, 0 Green, -5 Blue and Preserve Luminosity on.
3. Compare with the grade hidden. Keep only enough warmth to bring the materials together; the ocean does not need to become the same brown as the castle.
4. Inspect the brightest foam and the darkest eye. Reduce grade opacity if either loses texture. Save v05 with the previous checkpoint still available.

WHY The final grade is a unifying finish, not a replacement for local matching. Small changes preserve the differences between water, sand and shell.

CHECK Materials remain distinct and highlights retain detail. The image does not depend on an extreme yellow filter to look cohesive.

FIX When the whole image feels muddy, inspect local shadow layers before lifting the entire grade. Do not crush blacks to hide bad joins.

Adobe technique notes [3, 4, 12]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Guide attention with a gentle vignette

SELECT A new top Curves adjustment named 16_Vignette.



Full source-built reference. This is a constructed teaching composite, not an AI-generated final.

1. Set RGB Curves to Input 128, Output 110. Change the layer blend mode to Luminosity, then invert its white mask to black.
2. Choose a large soft white brush, approximately 700–900 px, Opacity 15%, Flow 15%. Paint lightly on the mask at the four corners.
3. Keep the centre, eye, tallest spire and front flipper mostly untouched. Lower the adjustment layer opacity until the effect is subtle.
4. Toggle the vignette at thumbnail size. Remove it when it closes the scene too much; a vignette is optional finishing, not evidence of technical competence by itself.

WHY Slight edge darkening can direct attention inward. The effect should support the composition rather than advertise itself.

CHECK The focal point reads faster, but the foreground cracks still have visible texture.

FIX Black corners are overdone. Paint black back onto the mask or reduce the curve strength. Do not erase any source layers.

Adobe technique notes [3]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Run the four-join quality check

SELECT The master PSD at 100%, then at Fit on Screen.

Final check | preserve the eye, shell edge and flipper



Critical final-detail inspection: eye, neck, front flipper and nearby material edges.

1. Inspect join 1: castle to platform. Remove rectangular sand edges, blue arch holes and semi-transparent walls. Edit the relevant castle mask.
2. Inspect join 2: platform to shell. Reveal the original shell rim; keep sand off the neck and face. Edit the platform mask, not the turtle.
3. Inspect join 3: turtle to ground. Fix pale fringes and misplaced shadows. Inspect join 4: foam to flipper. Remove a continuous white belt or obvious duplicate foam.
4. At Fit on Screen, check hierarchy: tallest castle first, turtle identity second, foreground third. Temporarily hide optional atmosphere/grade layers to see whether the joins still work.
5. Capture a before/after crop of one repair. Save it in Evidence with a brief explanation of the layer or mask you changed.

WHY A polished composite is won at the joins. Checking both 100% and whole-image scale separates technical edge quality from overall composition.

CHECK No missing anatomy, blue castle holes or hard rectangles remain. You have a documented repair, not just a final screenshot.

FIX Do not use extra glow, blur or darkness to conceal errors. Fix the mask, scale or local tone at the source of the problem.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Save the editable master and export a viewing copy

SELECT The master PSD; all intended layers visible.



Layer-order guide: your group names can differ, but the front-to-back relationships must work.

1. Rename groups and layers so another person can identify SKY, WORLD_OCEAN, GROUND, TURTLE, SAND, KINGDOM, FOAM and FINISH. Save as Working/Turtle_Kingdom_Lastname_FINAL.psd.
2. Keep Smart Objects and masks. Do not flatten the only PSD. Hide any diagnostic background, temporary monochrome layer or layout guide artwork.
3. Choose File > Export > Export As. Select JPG, 1600 × 1200 px, a high quality setting, Convert to sRGB and Embed Color Profile where offered. Export to Exports/Turtle_Kingdom_Lastname.jpg.
4. Fallback: use File > Save a Copy > JPEG after checking the document is sRGB. Reopen the exported image in a separate viewer to check dimensions, colour and visible edges.
5. Include a source-credit text file with the image. This package does not verify permission to publish every original stock asset publicly.

WHY The PSD preserves the process; the JPEG communicates the result. A clean export must be checked independently of the working file.

CHECK You have both a layered PSD and a 1600 × 1200 viewing image that opens correctly outside Photoshop.

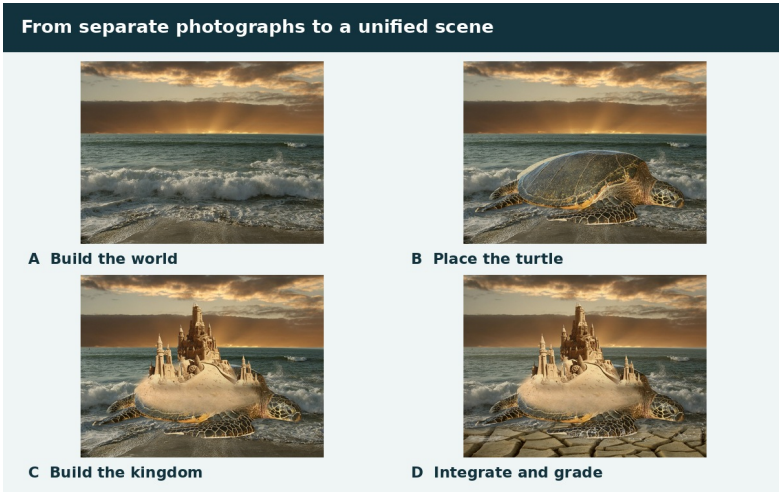
FIX A JPEG-only submission cannot show editable masks. Return to the layered working file. Changing a file extension does not convert its format.

Adobe technique notes [9]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Explain and demonstrate what you learned

SELECT Your final image, layered PSD and Evidence folder.



Evidence can show improvement across stages; the final image is not the only useful assessment product.

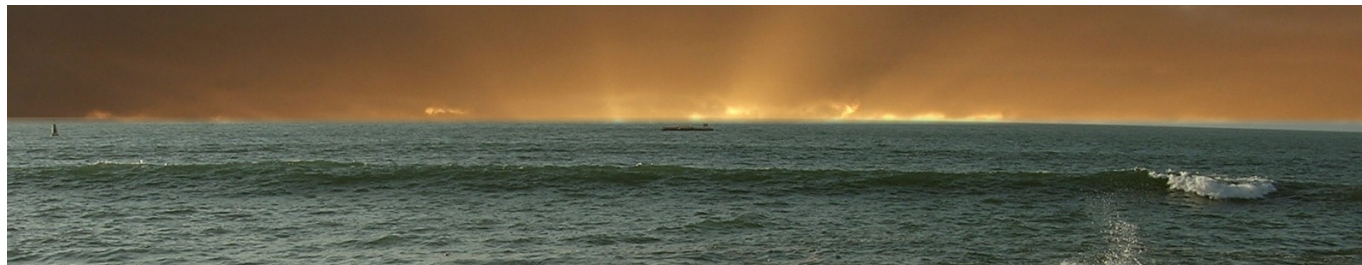
1. Submit the JPEG, layered PSD and three evidence crops: a mask/edge decision, a castle-to-shell join, and a foam or tone correction. Add source credits and disclose prepared assets.
2. For each crop, write three short sentences: What looked wrong? Which layer, mask or setting did you change? What improved in the result?
3. Prepare a 60-second demonstration: select a mask, hide a small area, restore it with white, then explain the difference between that mask and a clipping mask.
4. Complete one short transfer task chosen by your teacher: reposition the small gate and repair its contact shadow, or change the sky and rematch one subject. Keep the change reversible.
5. Export your browser notes at the end of the session. Browser checkboxes record progress, not a grade; the teacher assesses the work and your explanations.

WHY	An attractive image alone does not show which decisions you can repeat. Evidence and a short demonstration reveal transferable understanding.
CHECK	Your files open, credits are present, and you can explain one successful revision without reading the tutorial word for word.
FIX	Do not claim an AI concept or a prepared mask as your own construction. Identify the support, then demonstrate the skills you personally used.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Compare manual sky masking with Sky Replacement

SELECT A duplicate of the original ocean document, not your only finished master.



This optional comparison is not required to complete the core project.

1. Open the original ocean and Save As Working/Sky_Comparison.psd. Choose Edit > Sky Replacement when this command is available in the installed desktop version.
2. Open the sky picker, import your saved cloud crop and select it. Position and scale the sky until roofs are excluded and its brightness is plausible for the water.
3. Start with small Shift Edge/Fade Edge adjustments while inspecting the horizon. Set Output To: New Layers and click OK.
4. Inspect the generated sky/foreground masks and compare them with your manual mask from steps 4–5. Note one useful automation and one correction you still had to make.
5. Do not replace the main exercise with this result unless your teacher approves. When the command is unavailable, compare two manual sky placements instead.

WHY Comparing automation with a manual process makes the tool's strengths and limits visible. An automatic mask still needs inspection.

CHECK You retain both versions and can identify the layers/masks responsible for the effect.

FIX Run this in a duplicate source document. Applying it to a complex finished composite may classify castle openings or foam unexpectedly.

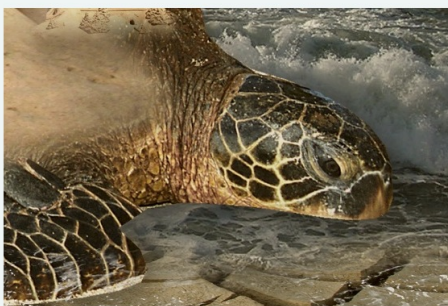
Adobe technique notes [10]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Add a small cracked-shell texture accent

SELECT A new dry003 texture layer above 03_Turtle and its corrections.

Final check | preserve the eye, shell edge and flipper



An optional creative variation; this accent is not included in the core reference.

1. Place Ground_Patch.psd again, name it Shell_Crack_Accent, and size it to cover only a small bare-shell region. Choose Layer > Create Clipping Mask with the turtle as the base.
2. Use Edit > Transform > Warp for a slight curve. Set blend mode Multiply and begin at 15% opacity.
3. Add a hide-all layer mask and reveal the texture in ONE small shell area with a soft white brush. Keep the eye, head, flippers and sand platform untouched.
4. Toggle the layer at 50% view. Reduce opacity or delete it if it confuses the natural shell pattern. Record why the accent improves—or weakens—the story.

WHY Selective texture can develop the surreal theme without replacing the subject's identity. More texture is not automatically better design.

CHECK The accent is local and reversible. The turtle still looks like a turtle, not a stone statue.

FIX When the texture covers several objects, the clipping chain is wrong. Put it directly in the turtle's clipping stack, or use a dedicated local mask.

Adobe technique notes [4, 6]. Project measurements and settings are authored starting points.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Turn the composite into an illustrated story cover

SELECT A saved copy named Turtle_Kingdom_Cover.psd.



Creative extension: the core reference intentionally contains no title so students make this decision.

1. Keep the master artwork unchanged. In the copy, choose the Type tool (T) and add live text "TURTLE KINGDOM" in a readable serif or bold sans serif available on the school computer.
2. Start around 70-90 px type size. Place the title in a clear area of sky, at least 60 px from the canvas edge, without touching the tallest spire.
3. Add one small subtitle, such as "A world carried by the tide", around 24-30 px. Use two text sizes and one alignment rather than multiple competing fonts.
4. When the sky makes the words hard to read, add a new dark pixel layer BELOW the type. Paint a soft local darkening at low opacity and mask it away from the castle.
5. Export a separate cover JPEG. Ask a partner to read the title at thumbnail size, then make one documented hierarchy revision.

WHY The artwork now has a communication purpose. Typography should add a clear reading order rather than cover the subject.

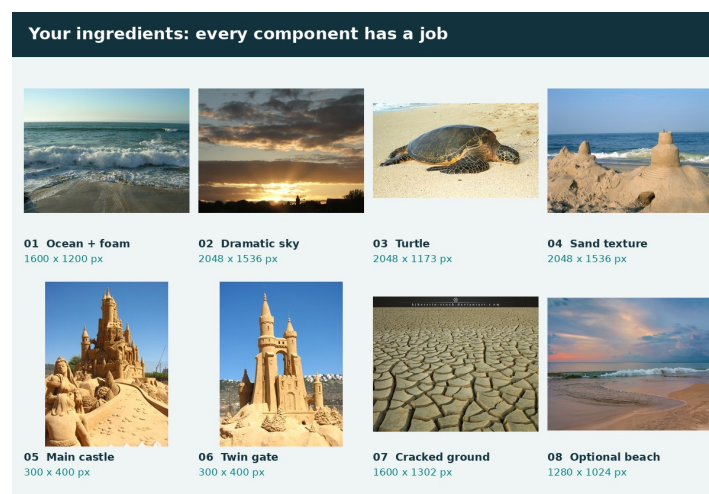
CHECK The title reads quickly, the castle remains visible and all type is editable.

FIX Do not flatten text to make it fit. Reduce its size, change the line break or move it to clearer sky.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Make an independent alternate mood

SELECT A copy of the finished layered file and 1180650_41162380.jpg.



The optional beach source is provided so no external image search is needed.

1. Save a new version as Turtle_Kingdom_Alternate.psd. Place 1180650_41162380.jpg below the existing world layers, keeping its proportions linked.
2. Temporarily hide the old ocean and sky. Scale the new beach to cover the canvas, then place its horizon near y=470. Keep the existing subject, ground and foam layers.
3. Return to the subject corrections. Adjust Turtle_Tone, the castle corrections and Global_Warmth so they fit the new softer pink-blue environment.
4. Reduce or rebuild the warm horizon haze. Inspect whether old foam still matches the new water; mask it more selectively when it does not.
5. Submit a side-by-side comparison and identify two settings you changed because the lighting context changed. Your goal is justified transfer, not a pixel-for-pixel copy.

WHY Reusing the same technique in a new lighting context tests understanding more effectively than following the same numbers again.

CHECK The alternate has a deliberate mood, believable joins and explanations linked to specific edits.

FIX A global pink filter alone is not sufficient. Revisit local brightness and material colour, especially the castle and foam.

☐ Checked ☐ Needs another pass Process note: _____

Troubleshooting desk 1

The sky and sea have a bright seam.

Likely cause: A strip of the old sky is still visible, or the layers do not overlap.

Repair: Target the ocean mask. Hide the thin blue strip, keep a narrow feather and ensure the replacement extends behind the sea.

The brush paints black on the animal.

Likely cause: The image thumbnail is selected instead of the mask.

Repair: Undo. Click the mask thumbnail and confirm its border is active before painting again.

Only part of the image moves.

Likely cause: A selection is active, or you are transforming the mask alone.

Repair: Select > Deselect; select the image thumbnail. Confirm the chain link connects image and mask, then transform.

My castle contains blue holes.

Likely cause: The arch and gaps were not included in background removal.

Repair: Select Color Range blue in the source, then fill black on its mask. Repair only the actual background openings.

The castle looks blurred.

Likely cause: The 300 × 400 source has been enlarged.

Repair: Use a smaller castle or accept modest source softness. Sharpening or a larger resolution number cannot restore missing original detail.

The castle has a rectangular bottom.

Likely cause: Its sandy path mask ends abruptly.

Repair: Paint on the outer castle mask at low opacity; keep walls opaque and fade only the lower sand skirt.

The turtle looks like a floating sticker.

Likely cause: The contact shadow is missing, distant, or outlines the whole animal.

Repair: Use a close underside shadow; hide any upper halo. Add a small foreground foam overlap at a lower edge.

Troubleshooting desk 2

The foam is a solid white belt.

Likely cause: Too much area is revealed, or Blend If is too strong.

Repair: Mask most of the patch away. Keep three small contact regions. Recheck the This Layer split and lower coverage.

The foam stays dark blue.

Likely cause: The wrong tonal slider or a pre-darkened source is being used.

Repair: Use the original ocean crop. Split This Layer black near 110/207; desaturate locally if needed.

The whole image changes when I adjust one object.

Likely cause: A local correction is not clipped.

Repair: Select that adjustment and Layer > Create Clipping Mask. Recheck which layer forms its base.

The platform is a perfect beige oval.

Likely cause: The mask is too geometric and the surface has little tonal variation.

Repair: Vary its edge and add local underside shading. Reveal the original shell rim; avoid covering the head or flippers.

The working file opens with the old background.

Likely cause: A hidden source Background was left visible in a cut-out PSD.

Repair: Open the embedded source, hide Background, save and return. Keep your original JPG separate.

The grain/contrast is hiding the eye.

Likely cause: Too much global grading or stacked local darkness.

Repair: Hide the finish group. Restore eye detail locally, then re-enable restrained finishing layers.

Browser progress disappears.

Likely cause: Storage may be blocked, cleared, or tied to a different file/location.

Repair: Export notes each session. Use the supplied JSON backup/import controls; do not rely on the browser as the only record.

Student reflection and evidence

Name / class: _____

My story in one sentence

Three decisions I can explain

Evidence	What looked wrong?	What did I change?	What improved?
Mask / edge			
Castle / shell join			
Foam / colour			

Supports and sources I used

Prepare a 60-second demonstration

Choose a mask. Hide a small area, restore it, and explain why this differs from a clipping mask. Then reposition a gate and repair its shadow, or change the sky and explain one local correction.

Submission check

☐ Layered PSD ☐ 1600 × 1200 JPEG ☐ Three evidence crops ☐ Source credits ☐ Prepared supports declared ☐ Browser notes exported

Teacher assessment: evidence first

Suggested rubric: four criteria scored 1–4, maximum 16. This is a proposed task rubric, not an official provincial/IB rubric or a recommended percentage conversion. “Not yet observed” is recorded separately, not automatically scored as 1.

Observation, conversation and product

Evidence channel	What to collect
Observation	Correct thumbnail selection, reversible mask repair, response to an edge problem.
Conversation	A short explanation of a contact shadow, local correction or clipping decision.
Product	Final image, editable PSD, credits and before/after evidence.

Three opportunities to show understanding

1. Guided build: a successful tool use with explanation. 2. Documented repair: diagnose and correct a join. 3. Transfer: apply the method to a repositioned gate or new sky.

Fair supported participation

Allow prepared cut-outs where appropriate, but do not treat a downloaded mask as independent selection evidence. Gather a smaller independent masking sample when that competency is being assessed. Do not reward extra decoration, speed or extra steps instead of quality.

Optional formative check and answer cues

Why is a mask better than erasing here? It can hide and restore source content. Why clip Ocean_Tone? It must not change other layers. Why split Blend If? It creates partial transparency across tones. Why does an arch still show blue? Its internal background was never removed.

Suggested rubric 1

Masks and editable construction

Level	Descriptor
4 · Secure / transferable	Precise masks, intact details and clearly editable construction; independently diagnoses and repairs a difficult edge.
3 · Meets the task	Main masks work, key details remain, and named layers/Smart Objects preserve the process.
2 · Developing	Some useful masks, but visible fringes, missing details or flattened stages need support.
1 · Beginning	Limited evidence of masking; important elements are erased/flattened or incomplete.

Spatial integration

Level	Descriptor
4 · Secure / transferable	Scale, material joins, overlap and contact shadows work consistently; a difficult join is deliberately refined.
3 · Meets the task	Castle rests on the shell, turtle meets the surface, and at least one foam overlap creates depth.
2 · Developing	Some convincing joins, but floating pieces, rectangles or conflicting overlap remain.
1 · Beginning	Objects remain separate-looking with major placement or contact problems.

Suggested rubric 2

Colour, tone and visual intention

Level	Descriptor
4 · Secure / transferable	Local and global decisions form a coherent mood with preserved detail; changes are justified against the intention.
3 · Meets the task	Brightness and colour are broadly matched and the focal point is clear.
2 · Developing	Partial matching; some pasted-looking colour or brightness differences remain.
1 · Beginning	Strong mismatches obscure the intended scene or subject.

Explanation and transfer

Level	Descriptor
4 · Secure / transferable	Explains cause and effect precisely, demonstrates repair independently and adapts the method to a new context.
3 · Meets the task	Explains a revision and demonstrates a mask correction or teacher-selected transfer task.
2 · Developing	Can describe some actions but needs prompts to explain or transfer them.
1 · Beginning	Cannot yet explain the key decisions or demonstrate the assessed operation.

Teacher delivery and preflight

Class	Focus	Checkpoint
1	Steps 1-6	Build the world; demonstrate image versus mask.
2	Steps 7-11	Turtle selection, edge check and local tone.
3	Steps 12-20	Shell platform and main castle; inspect the join.
4	Steps 21-26	Gates, contact shadows and foreground materials.
5	Steps 27-34	Foam, lighting, finishing and a documented repair.
6	Steps 35-36 / extensions	Export, short demonstration and transfer task.

Before students work independently

1. Confirm the desktop Photoshop version and file-opening permissions on a student account, not just an administrator account.
2. Try one turtle selection and confirm Select and Mask can output the intended layer mask. Use Polygonal/Quick Selection when automatic selection is unavailable.
3. Open both castle thumbnails at the intended display size. Decide whether their softness is acceptable; reduce their size if necessary.
4. Test Free Transform pixel fields and the top-left reference point. If the installed interface differs, demonstrate Properties > Transform plus visual alignment to guides.
5. Test the foam crop and split This Layer black slider at 110/207. Adjust thresholds if source colour management changes the result.
6. Open the packaged HTML locally. Test one original download, a support PNG, a progress checkbox, notes export and backup import.
7. Check stock permissions before any public upload. Keep the original credit bands and filenames and request missing source information.
8. Choose whether prepared masks are allowed and what independent selection evidence is required. Assess image decisions, not speed or number of decorative extras.

Research notes 1

Primary Adobe references checked 17 September 2026. The source images, project sequence, settings, diagrams and assessment are distinct from these tool-behaviour references. Links are clickable in the PDF; internet access is required.

[1] Embedded Smart Objects

Adobe documents File > Place Embedded and conversion to Smart Objects. Placement measurements in this guide are our project recipe.

Open Adobe reference: [Embedded Smart Objects](#)

[2] Layer masks

Adobe reference for non-destructive hiding and revealing. The project-specific mask locations and brush settings are authored for these sources.

Open Adobe reference: [Layer masks](#)

[3] Curves

Reference for Curves adjustment layers and Input/Output values. All curve numbers here are adjustable starting points.

Open Adobe reference: [Curves](#)

[4] Clipping masks

Reference for restricting upper layers to a base layer.

Open Adobe reference: [Clipping masks](#)

[5] Select and Mask

Reference for edge views, refinements and mask output.

Open Adobe reference: [Select and Mask](#)

[6] Transform Warp

Reference for editable deformation controls. Warp is used on texture, not to distort the animal or upright architecture.

Open Adobe reference: [Transform Warp](#)

Research notes 2

Primary Adobe references checked 17 September 2026. The source images, project sequence, settings, diagrams and assessment are distinct from these tool-behaviour references. Links are clickable in the PDF; internet access is required.

[7] Color Range

Reference for sampled colours, Fuzziness and additions/subtractions.

[Open Adobe reference: Color Range](#)

[8] Blend If and blending

Reference for splitting tonal sliders in Layer Style. The 110/207 foam split is our source-specific starting point.

[Open Adobe reference: Blend If and blending](#)

[9] Export workflows

Adobe guidance on export preferences and viewing-copy workflows; labels can vary by installed version.

[Open Adobe reference: Export workflows](#)

[10] Sky Replacement

Reference for the optional comparison exercise; the core uses a manual layer mask.

[Open Adobe reference: Sky Replacement](#)

[11] Clone Stamp

Optional troubleshooting reference for cloning on separate layers with Current & Below sampling.

[Open Adobe reference: Clone Stamp](#)

[12] Color Balance

Adobe reference for Shadows/Midtones/Highlights, colour sliders and Preserve Luminosity.

[Open Adobe reference: Color Balance](#)